

Fostering a Future-Ready Skilled Workforce



In today's rapidly evolving global landscape, where the dynamics of work, workers, and workplaces are constantly shifting, the role of human resources management has taken centre stage. SHRM, a global authority on all things work, has been at the forefront of addressing the challenges and opportunities in this ever-changing environment.

Recently, SHRM collaborated with India Today to present 'Shaping a New World of Work, Worker & Workplace' during the B20 Summit in New Delhi, where Rajdeep Sardesai, Consulting Editor of India Today discussed critical workforce mobility and skilling issues with Johnny C. Taylor, Jr., President and CEO of SHRM and co-chair of the B20 Task Force on the Future of Work, Skilling and Mobility. Their discussion delved into the profound impact of the global pandemic on these issues.

Johnny C. Taylor, Jr. pointed out how the pandemic presented a unique opportunity for people to reflect on their relationship with work. "It prompted individuals to ponder where, when, and how they work, as well as the nature of their work itself," he said. The resounding realization was that work is not merely about earning a living; it's about fulfilment, purpose and workplace culture.

Remote work also gave organizations a chance to rethink traditional structures. Today, many enterprises are experimenting with hybrid work arrangements which encompass both productivity and relationship-building among employees.

Johnny C. Taylor, Jr. explained how in the new emerging order, organizations have begun to view employees as they do customers, prioritizing well-being and development. An employee-first

approach recognizes the importance of human capital in today's knowledge-based economy. At the same time, digital technology adoption has begun to highlight access and skill gaps. He noted, "India, with its youthful population, needs to focus on early-stage primary education and collaborate with the private sector to align education with evolving industry needs."

When asked about the top three recommendations his taskforce had presented at the B20, the crux of his enumeration was commitment to lifelong learning, inclusion of women in the workforce and mind-set change and access. Effectively, he recommended that changing attitudes and providing quality education for all are vital for future workforce development.

The discussion also touched on India's young and skilled workforce and how it could become a supply of talent to countries with demographic challenges. Johnny C. Taylor, Jr. noted this would require a shift in policies of host countries to enable more fluid workforce mobility across borders.

He went on to outline various other trends emerging in the HR space and how the domain has evolved from administrative tasks to a competitive business differentiator. With automation, AI, and machine learning creating new opportunities, reskilling is necessary to allow human workers to shift to higher-value roles. Successfully navigating these and other transitions will play a crucial role in shaping the future of work, workers and workplaces and driving economic growth.

